Ramachandra Guha, Jose Dominic, Abdul Hakim and Lalji Singh for their many suggestions. Let me also thank the Lal Bahadur Shastri National Academy of Administration (Mussourie), the Survey of India (Dehradun), the World-Wide Fund for Nature, the Archaeological Survey of India, Madhya Pradesh Tourism, The Sushant School of Art and Architecture, Vivekananda Kendra and the Institute of South East Asian Studies, Singapore.

I enjoyed the hospitality of many kind hosts on my travels. Let me take this opportunity to thank Suresh Neotia, Upendra Gupta, Sajjan and Sangita Jindal, Dushyant Singh, Abhijit Pandit, Sheila Nair, Maharaj Gaj Singh, Ranjit Barthakur, Shree Raman, Vineet Saran and Praveen Rengaraj. My dear friends Jayant Sinha, Peter Ruprecht, Ashish Goyal, Siddharth Yog and Arvind Sethi read drafts at different stages and gave me useful insights on style and readability.

Of course, the book would not have been possible without the diligence and enthusiasm of my editors Udayan Mitra and Ameya Nagarajan. It was a pleasure working with them. I am also grateful for the support of my extended family, particularly my father, with whom I continue to debate the meaning of the *Rig Veda*. Lastly, I wish to thank my wife Smita who put her life on hold for almost three years, accompanied me on my travels and patiently heard me read out the very first draft of each chapter.